MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 3/18/26 lw

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

Unapproved minutes
February 18, 2026

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Dale Majewski, District 3 Jacob Gross, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis and District 8 George Gilmore

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 9 Rick Fancon

OTHERS PRESENT

Administrator Lori Phelps, Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger, Deputy Clerk Isha Walter, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the agenda as presented with the addition, **Motion carried.**

*Addition: XI. D - Clerk/Election Agreement

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Gross to approve the Board of Commissioners Minutes of January 21, 2026, **Motion carried**.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

None

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. Osceola Planning Commission Notice – No Discussion
2. MMR Response Average Report – No Discussion
3. Garfield Township Recreation Plan – No Discussion
4. Lincoln Township Recreation Plan – No Discussion
5. Resolution from St. Joseph County Opposing Legislation Preempting Local Control for Data Center Construction/Battery Storage Facilities – No Discussion
6. MME Report – No Discussion

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

1. Eric Karbowski - Michigan State University (MSU) Extension
   Eric Karbowski, District Director for MSU Extension, appeared before the Board of Commissioners to request approval of the Millage Renewal Resolution #26-05 for MSU Extension for the August Primary Election.

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS - continued

2. Carol Majewski - Clare County Senior Services
   Carol Majewski, Director of Senior Services, gave an update on the number of Clare County residents currently being served through the various programs offered. More importantly, Carol Majewski announced that five Clare County Senior Services staff members were recently awarded the Direct Care Worker Retention Grant through Region VII Area Agency on Aging. She named Christy Diehl, Anna McConnell, Mary Hubbard, Stephanie Yonkman and Brandi Dvonch as the beneficiaries of the grant. The grant is awarded to recruit and retain experienced staff in the Direct Care workforce.

Recess at 09:08 a.m.
Back in session at 09:16 a.m.

JUSTICE

1. Undersheriff Williams – Sally Port Discussion
   Clare County Undersheriff Ed Williams addressed the Board of Commissioners regarding the Clare County Sheriff's Department desire for a newly constructed sally port. A sally port is a controlled area where inmates are securely transferred between vehicles and the Sheriff's Department building. The current area lacks the appropriate amount of space needed to accommodate multiple vehicles, including an ambulance. The proposed sally port would allow capacity for up to three vehicles and also provide the Sheriff's Department an area needed for the body scanner approved for purchase in 2024. Funding for the project will initially be paid from the Sheriff's Department General fund and will be reimbursed through the Commissary fund.

   After some discussion, it was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the project for the sally port and scanner, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Gross, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Kleinhardt and Majewski
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Fancon
   Motion carried.

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

1. Area Agency Appointment
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to re-appoint Mike Tobin to the Region VII Area Agency on Aging Board of Directors for a three-year term expiring March 31, 2029, **Motion carried**.

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

1. MSU Extension
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Resolution 26-05 to submit to the Electorate a Millage Renewal request for MSU Extension Services and 4-H and approving ballot language, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Majewski, Kleinhardt, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gross, Gilmore and Ambrozaitis
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Fancon
   Motion carried.

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT - continued

2. Drain
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the hiring of a full-time Deputy Drain Clerk to replace current Clerk retiring, **Motion carried.**

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of January 20, 2026 in the amount of $127,537.75 and the meeting minutes of February 2, 2026 in the amount of $70,605.95, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Gilmore, Ambrozaitis, Majewski, Kleinhardt, Gross, Haskell, Hoefling and Housler
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Fancon
   Motion carried.

2. Monthly Expenditures
   It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the expenditures for the month of January 2026 in the amount of $2,360,266.23 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,456,558.28, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Hoefling, Kleinhardt, Majewski, Gilmore, Gross, Housler, Ambrozaitis and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Fancon
   Motion carried.

3. Budget Adjustments – None

4. Clerk/Election Agreement
   It was moved by Commissioner Gross, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the 2026-2027 County Agreement for Election Services and Ballot Programming as required by the Bureau of Elections, **Motion carried**.

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps reported that Governor Whitmer presented the proposed 2027 budget on February 13, 2026. The County revenue sharing numbers remain the same. Several grants are on the horizon including one to assist with cybersecurity funding. She shared that the request to Michigan Indigent Defense Commission (MIDC) to use grant funds for cost allocation (to cover the cost of administering the grant) was denied with no reason for the denial. Lastly, Administrator Phelps reported that the budget should be 41.67% expensed; however, the county is currently 32.41% expensed.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory reports to the Commissioners showing the current cash, investments and fund balances. Her office is prepared for the Rabies Clinic which will be held this Saturday, February 21, 2026. She reminded the Commissioners that the tax deadlines at the local and county levels are coming soon.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman Gilmore reported that he has attended his meetings and there is nothing serious going on and added that he recently attended the Clare County Road Commission's informative workshop at the Career and Technical Education (CTE) building.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Fancon was absent.

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Housler has attended her meetings, nothing to report.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis reported that the radio for the Airport lighting system has been installed and is fully operational. He will be traveling to Lansing with Airport Manager Emerson Corder and will give an update at the next meeting.

Commissioner Hoefling reported that Frost Township is concerned with the State's unfunded mandates specifically regarding updating election equipment. Hamilton Township's five year plan was recently approved and the park construction is well underway. Lastly, Commissioner Hoefling stated that the Mid Michigan Community Action Agency is transitioning to a whole family programming. This new set up will allow clients to be aware of all the programs every member in the family is eligible for. He also thanked the Clare County Road Commission for their recent workshop.

Commissioner Kleinhardt had no report.

Commissioner Haskell had no report.

Commissioner Gross stated that he plans to attend the Policy Oversight Board meeting in Lansing.

Commissioner Majewski reported that Lake George is moving forward with the grant received for improvements at Shingle Lake Park. He congratulated Commissioner Haskell for his appointment as the new chair for the Central Michigan Health District.

PUBLIC COMMENT

A Clare County resident asked for clarification on what constitutes Section A and Section B on the Mobile Medical Response (MMR) response average report. He also expressed concern that a discussion in regards to The Country's Motto/Ten Commandments is on the agenda. In his opinion, no government should post any particular religious materials.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

None

NEW BUSINESS

Country's Motto/Ten Commandments Discussion
Commissioner Gilmore opened discussion on displaying the National Motto and Ten Commandments in the courthouse. He explained that in 2019 the Supreme Court ruled that the National Motto and Ten Commandments are allowed in all public buildings. Commissioner Ambrozaitis replied that he would like to see the court ruling. Commissioner Majewski added that there are different versions of the Ten Commandments and selecting one version over another may upset people.

It was moved by Commissioner Gilmore to go ahead and do this, there was no second to the motion, **motion failed**.

ADJOURNMENT

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Housler to adjourn, **motion carried.**

Meeting adjourned at 10:18 a.m.

Isha Walter, Deputy Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

George Gilmore, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners